

Seventh anniversary of the Apology on Friday 13 February 2015: The personal stories behind the Apology

Pope John Paul II's challenge in 1986:

'And the Church herself in Australia will not be fully the Church that Jesus wants her to be until you have made your contribution to her life and until that contribution has been joyfully received by others'. *Responding to this challenge and on this day, please consider taking a moment to reflect prayerfully by watching the video and reading the information listed below by Reconciliation Australia*

<https://www.reconciliation.org.au> **The Apology (It's Time) Music Video**

(featuring Kevin Rudd's historic apology to the native peoples of Australia, photography from Russell James as well as vocals from Will.i.am and Clifton Bieundurry).



The Apology to the Stolen Generations by the Australian Government in 2008 was an important step towards building a respectful new relationship between First Australians and other Australians. It was an important starting point in healing the wounds of the past and an historic step forward for our nation—something all Australians can be proud of. The Apology was not an expression of personal responsibility or guilt by individuals but it did reflect our Australian values of compassion, justice and a 'fair go'. It also allowed the victims of bad policy to feel that their pain

and suffering has been acknowledged.

It's crucial that all Australians understand the background to the Apology in order to realise the great potential of this historic moment to move our nation forward.

To mark the seventh anniversary of the Apology on Friday 13 February 2015, here are some of the stories of St Generations members,

to whom the Apology paid respect. **Avis Gale:** At just one week old, Avis Gale was removed from her mother by the Aboriginal Protection Board and sent to the Colebrook Home run by the United Aborigines' Mission in Adelaide, 500 miles away from her home near Ceduna. The enforced religion and sexual abuse she suffered at the mission had a deep impact on Avis' life. [Read more of Avis' story.](#)

Bill Simon: Bill Simon was forced to leave his family to be "re-educated" to the European way of life. His removal created great hurt and began a big rejection problem that would affect his life for many years. He describes life as a Ward of the State as not too different from being in the Army.

[Read more of Bill's story.](#)

Tjalaminu Mia: Tjalaminu Mia, along with her six brothers and sisters, was taken from her family and placed in Sister Kate's Children's Home. Separated from her siblings at the home,

the shock of going from the richness of family life to an isolated environment was almost more than she could bear. This made it very difficult for her to relate to people later in life.

[Read more of Tjalaminu's story.](#)

More stories from members of the Stolen Generations can be found on the [Australian Human Rights Commission's website](#).

For more information and resources about the Apology, visit the websites of the [National Sorry Day Committee](#) and the [Healing Foundation](#);

read Reconciliation Australia's [factsheet](#) or watch Dr [Tom Calma's response to the Apology](#). [Close the Gap media release](#)